

Week 10 Reading Notes & Synthesis

A journey through frameworks, philosophy, and the persistent question of what teaching is actually for.

Hinchliffe - Education or Pedagogy?

Hinchliffe wrestles with the distinction between 'education' and 'pedagogy,' arguing that we've let pedagogy become instrumentalized—reduced to a set of techniques divorced from questions about what education is actually for. He draws on Oakeshott's metaphor of education as 'conversation' to resist this instrumentalization, but even this beautiful metaphor risks becoming another tool we wield rather than a practice we inhabit. The article's dense philosophical language can feel like gatekeeping, but beneath it is a crucial question: Does education already involve normative judgments (it does), and should we make those explicit rather than letting them hide in dominant colonial structures?

Key quote from my reading: 'Doesn't it already do this? It's often just implicit and baked into the dominant, colonial structure's norms.' This captures my main pushback—Hinchliffe wants to distinguish education from pedagogy to preserve something open and non-instrumental, but in practice, all educational acts already carry values and power dynamics. The question isn't whether education involves normative judgments, but whether we're honest about them.

The article's discussion of 'bricolage'—the practice of making do with materials at hand—offers a more grounded way to think about teaching. As I noted, 'The bricoleur angle was fascinating because it acknowledges constraint and improvisation as features, not bugs.' This connects to my lived experience: good teaching isn't about having the perfect resources; it's about resourcefulness, adaptation, and working within real constraints.

Koehler & Mishra - TPACK Framework

Koehler and Mishra present the Technological Pedagogical Content Knowledge (TPACK) framework as a way to represent how teachers need to navigate the complex intersections of technology, pedagogy, and content knowledge. The framework resists the idea that you can simply 'add' technology to existing teaching practice; instead, it argues that effective technology integration requires understanding how these three domains interact and transform each other. TPACK emerges from the earlier Pedagogical Content Knowledge (PCK) work of Shulman, extended to account for the rapid technological changes reshaping education. During our discussion, I pushed back on frameworks generally, noting 'I am always wary of frameworks and schemas. The moment you make one, people take it as prescriptive rather than descriptive.' This tension runs throughout the article—TPACK wants to capture complexity, but risks becoming another checklist that flattens the nuanced, context-dependent work of teaching. The framework can be useful for thinking about teacher knowledge, but it can't replace the judgment, improvisation, and responsiveness that actual teaching requires.

The article does acknowledge that context matters deeply—what works in one setting may fail completely in another—but this acknowledgment sits uneasily with

the desire to create a generalizable framework. As I noted in our conversation, technology is never neutral: 'All technology is made by humans with explicit and implicit biases and often carries a cultural weight or footprint that may or may not be compatible with learning and the learners.' TPACK tries to account for this, but frameworks inevitably abstract away from the messy particulars where teaching actually happens.

Duckworth - The Having of Wonderful Ideas

Eleanor Duckworth's essay makes the case that children's intellectual development depends on having 'wonderful ideas'—moments of genuine discovery, connection, and understanding that emerge from curiosity and exploration. She describes an educational environment that sounds like paradise: small groups, trusted educators with deep insights into children's thinking, and the flexibility to follow children's interests and questions. The essay centers children's agency and celebrates the intellectual work they do when given space to wonder, question, and explore.

I connected immediately to this vision because it mirrors my own homeschooling experience: 'That sounds like a paradise! It also sounds a whole lot like how my parents home schooled the three of us and by extension our co-op group.' But this also raised the crucial question of scale—how do you take something that works beautifully in small, resource-rich, highly intentional settings and make it work in public schools serving hundreds or thousands of students with varying levels of resources, support, and preparation?

Duckworth doesn't directly address this scaling challenge, which makes the essay both inspiring and frustrating. Her vision of education is one where teachers have time to observe, listen, and respond to individual children's thinking—where curriculum emerges from student questions rather than predetermined standards. This is pedagogically sound and developmentally appropriate, but it requires structural conditions (small groups, adequate time, teacher expertise, institutional support) that most schools don't have. The essay invites us to imagine what education could be while leaving us to wrestle with the gap between that vision and current reality.

Reflecting on Duckworth's call to value children's wonderful ideas, I realize: 'Sometimes we spend so much time focusing on what's broken or not working that we forget to have our own wonderful ideas about what could be.' This connects directly to Duckworth's argument—when we're consumed by deficit thinking about students, schools, or systems, we lose the capacity for the very thing she's advocating: curiosity-driven discovery and creative problem-solving.

Perkins - Teaching for Understanding

David Perkins argues for a 'performance perspective' on understanding—the idea that understanding isn't just knowing facts, but being able to do things with knowledge. He writes that understanding involves making connections 'between students' lives and the subject matter, between principles and practice, between the past and the present.' His framework emphasizes that students demonstrate understanding by using knowledge flexibly in new contexts, explaining concepts in their own words, finding examples, and applying ideas to solve problems.

I was immediately skeptical, noting 'Everyone says they want connections. That's educational theory 101. The question is whether Perkins is going to tell us how to do that in ways that don't collapse into instrumental thinking.' While Perkins offers useful categories for thinking about understanding (explanation, interpretation, application, having perspective, empathy, and self-knowledge), these categories risk becoming another checklist if teachers don't have the time, support, and expertise to use them thoughtfully.

The article's strength is its insistence that understanding is active and demonstrated through performance. Understanding isn't a static possession; it's something students do. But Perkins, like Duckworth, describes an idealized version of teaching that assumes teachers have time to design rich performance tasks, observe student thinking, provide meaningful feedback, and adjust instruction based on what they learn. The gap between this vision and the reality of teaching under standardized testing regimes, rigid pacing guides, and large class sizes goes largely unaddressed.

Wiggins & McTighe - Backward Design

Wiggins and McTighe present 'backward design' as a framework for curriculum planning that starts with the end in mind. Rather than beginning with activities or content coverage, backward design asks teachers to first identify desired learning outcomes, then determine what evidence would demonstrate that students have achieved those outcomes, and only then plan instruction. The three stages are elegantly simple: (1) Identify desired results, (2) Determine acceptable evidence, (3) Plan learning experiences and instruction.

During our discussion, I identified feedback as a through-line across all the week's readings: 'All these articles either explicitly or implicitly highlight the critical importance of timely, meaningful feedback throughout the learning process—from the teacher, their peers, or through self-reflection.' I connected this to my own practice of 'cheating the gradebook'—using completion grades for homework and rubrics for major assessments so I could spend time actually engaging with student work rather than assigning points. This shift from 'everything must be graded' to 'this is not a points game' freed me to do the work backward design actually calls for.

I framed backward design as 'training wheels' or 'bumpers' for curriculum design: 'Just like with students, you have to start with some foundational skills and bumpers. As your students, or you, become more independent and confident, then you start taking the bumpers off.' The formulaic nature of the framework isn't a bug—it's a feature for novice teachers learning to think systematically about goals, evidence, and instruction. But experienced teachers who've internalized that backwards logic shouldn't need the elaborate design considerations chart. They can just think: What matters? How will I know? What'll get us there?

Synthesis: Frameworks, Practice, and the Problem of Scale

These five readings circle the same fundamental tensions in education: the gap between idealized visions and institutional realities, the risk of instrumentalizing open

practices, and the persistent question of what teaching is actually for. Each author offers a different angle on these questions, but they all bump up against similar constraints—time, resources, scale, and the grinding pressure of standardized accountability systems.

Hinchliffe worries that pedagogy has become instrumentalized, reduced to techniques divorced from questions of purpose and value. But as I pushed back in our discussion, education already involves normative judgments—the so-called 'neutral' transmission of knowledge is always embedded in particular cultural and colonial frameworks that get treated as universal. The question isn't whether to make normative judgments, but whether to make them explicit. When we hide those judgments in dominant structures, we reproduce existing inequities. When we name them, we create space for critique and transformation.

The TPACK framework tries to capture the complexity of teacher knowledge in the digital age, acknowledging that technology, pedagogy, and content knowledge interact in ways that transform all three. But frameworks are slippery things—they start as descriptive tools to help us think, and they quickly become prescriptive checklists that administrators use to evaluate teachers. As I noted, 'The moment you make one, people take it as prescriptive rather than descriptive.' This isn't TPACK's fault, exactly, but it's a predictable consequence of trying to represent messy, context-dependent practice in clean, generalizable models.

Duckworth's vision of education—small groups, trusted educators, space for children to have wonderful ideas—is beautiful and developmentally sound. But it describes conditions that most schools can't provide. The essay doesn't grapple with questions of scale, equity, or resource constraints. What happens when you have 150 students, not 15? What happens when teachers don't have the preparation, support, or time to observe children's thinking carefully? What happens when standardized tests and rigid pacing guides leave no room for following student questions?

Duckworth describes an educational paradise, but offers limited guidance for how to work toward that vision within existing institutional constraints.

Yet Duckworth's call to value wonderful ideas offers something crucial: 'Sometimes we spend so much time focusing on what's broken or not working that we forget to have our own wonderful ideas about what could be.' This isn't naive optimism—it's a reminder that critique without imagination is sterile. We need both: clear-eyed analysis of structural constraints AND the capacity to envision alternatives. The challenge is holding both simultaneously without letting either collapse into the other. Perkins and Wiggins & McTighe both offer practical frameworks for curriculum design—teaching for understanding and backward design, respectively. These frameworks are useful, but they assume conditions that don't exist in many schools: time for thoughtful planning, small enough class sizes to observe student thinking, flexibility to adjust instruction based on formative assessment, and freedom from external accountability pressures. My 'training wheels' metaphor captures something important here: these frameworks can help novice teachers learn to think systematically about goals, evidence, and instruction. But experienced teachers shouldn't need elaborate design considerations charts—they've internalized the logic and can improvise responsively.

The through-line I identified—feedback as central to learning—cuts across all these readings. Whether we're talking about Duckworth's educators observing children's thinking, Perkins' performance-based understanding, or Wiggins & McTighe's formative assessment, the common element is ongoing, responsive feedback that helps students understand their own learning. In my own practice, this meant

'cheating the gradebook'—using completion grades and rubrics strategically so I could spend time actually engaging with student work rather than sorting students into rankings. The shift from 'everything must be graded' to 'this is not a points game' freed me to do the work all these authors implicitly call for.

My most significant pushback across all these readings is about homework and independent practice. The authors assume that students need solo practice time to develop independence and metacognitive skills, but I'm deeply skeptical of this claim. 'Research shows that [homework] is really ineffective in all but some very niche cases AND it conditions students to work for free outside their normal work hours.' When I said 'this fixation on solo practice is also really weird to me. Who works in isolation these days?' I was pointing to a disconnect between how we structure school and how people actually work and learn in the world. If we're doing it right, students develop the ability and confidence to have wonderful ideas both in collaboration and independently—but that capacity emerges from rich, supported practice during class time, not from isolated homework grinding.

The meta-question running through all these readings is whether frameworks, models, and systematic approaches can capture what good teaching actually requires. Hinchliffe suggests that the instrumental colonization of pedagogy is inevitable when we try to systematize practice. TPACK tries to resist this by acknowledging complexity, but risks becoming another tool for evaluation and control. Duckworth sidesteps the question by describing conditions that would make frameworks unnecessary—if you have small groups and deep relationships, you don't need elaborate models to guide your practice. Perkins and Wiggins & McTighe offer their frameworks as tools for thinking, but can't control how those tools get used once they enter institutional settings.

In the end, I keep returning to bricolage—making do with what you have, working within constraints, improvising solutions that fit your particular context. This isn't a framework; it's a stance toward practice that acknowledges that teaching is always situated, always constrained, and always requires judgment that can't be captured in models or rubrics. The readings this week offered useful ways to think about curriculum design, teacher knowledge, and student learning. But they can't replace the responsiveness, creativity, and ethical judgment that teaching requires. That work remains ours to do.

Questions for Consideration

For Class Discussion

If all educational practices already carry implicit normative judgments (as Hinchliffe suggests), what would it look like to make those judgments explicit in our teaching? How might naming our values and assumptions create space for critique and transformation rather than simply reproducing existing power structures?

For Personal Reflection

When have I experienced the gap between an idealized vision of teaching (like Duckworth's) and the institutional realities I navigate? What strategies have I

developed for working within constraints while still honoring my core values about teaching and learning?

The 'training wheels' metaphor suggests that frameworks become less necessary as expertise develops. What aspects of my teaching practice still feel like they need structure and support, and what aspects feel more intuitive and responsive? How do I know when I'm ready to 'take the bumpers off' in a particular domain?

For Final Project Exploration

How might an auto-ethnography trace the movement from framework-dependent practice to more intuitive, responsive teaching? What artifacts, reflections, or documentation would capture that trajectory?

Thinking about my website as a pedagogical artifact: What implicit values and assumptions are embedded in how I've structured it? What would it look like to make those explicit in ways that invite critique rather than simply presenting my practice as exemplary?

The concept of 'bricolage' offers a lens for examining how I've adapted tools, frameworks, and ideas to fit my particular contexts and constraints. How might I use auto-ethnography to explore the improvisational, situated nature of my teaching rather than presenting it as a replicable model?